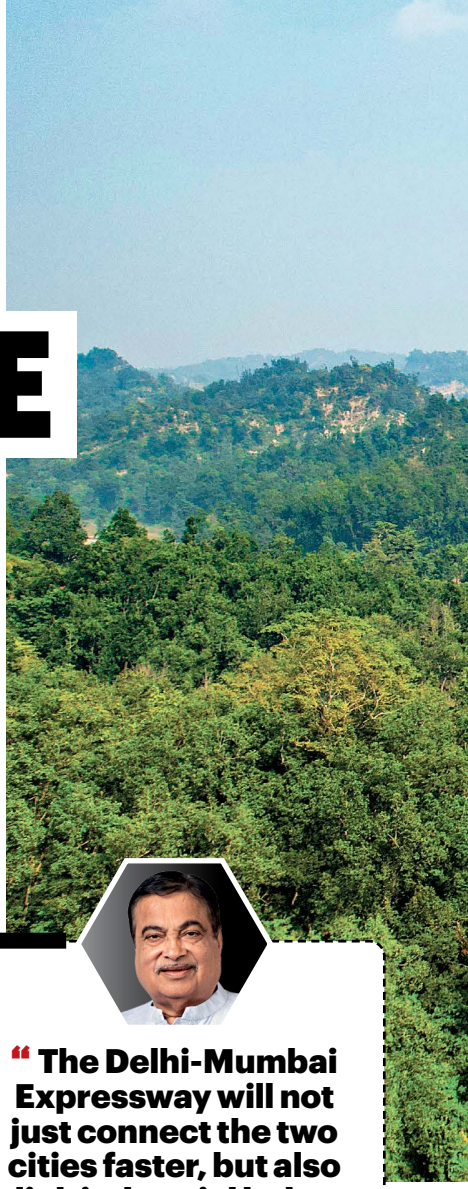
REMOVING THE ROADBLOCKS

After years of delays, flagship expressways across India are nearing completion, promising shorter travel times and a boost to economic growth

By AVISHEK G. DASTIDAR



For years, Vinay Rawat, a 37-year-old schoolteacher in Dehradun, has been planning his visits to Delhi like a small military operation. Seven hours on a good day. Longer if traffic near Meerut is clogged up or roadwork has turned the highway into a bottlenecked trench. His parents in Delhi are getting older. Time, he says, is never enough and it is the only thing that stops him from visiting them often. By mid-2026, that grim arithmetic of distance and delay may change forever. The Delhi-Dehradun Expressway promises to cut the journey to roughly two and a half hours. Not merely a saving of time—it promises a fundamentally different life.

Behind such changing realities lies the Bharatmala Pariyojana, the government's flagship highway development programme started a decade ago to overhaul India's road network through a corridor-based approach. It covers about 34,800 km of highways at an estimated cost of Rs 5.35 lakh crore. As of January, projects covering 21,783 km out of the awarded 26,425 km stand constructed, spending a little over 99 per cent of that money. With new project sanctions discontinued a couple of years ago, the entire road-building machinery moved to completion and enterprise mode. The result: after years of missed deadlines, some of India's most ambitious projects are finally inching toward completion. If most of them open as scheduled, it would be the largest change in highway connectivity since the Golden Quadrilateral, impacting India's every corner.

The Delhi-Dehradun Expressway cuts through the Shivaliks via long tunnels (see *The Last Mile*), while the Delhi-Mumbai Expressway forms the spine of a new northwest logistics axis. Ahmedabad is drawn closer to the proposed industrial city of Dholera. Half-day journeys between Bengaluru and Chennai are compressed into a single four-hour run. Amritsar is brought closer to Jamnagar via Bathinda, connecting energy, port and refinery hubs. The Lucknow-Kanpur stretch will be a swift 30-45-minute drive. When the Delhi-Amritsar-Katra Expressway opens, Amritsar will be just four hours from Delhi, and Katra six—down from a gruelling 13-hour journey. The Gurugram-Pataudi highway provides direct access to the Dwarka Expressway, easing connectivity around one of the NCR's most persistent choke points.

"The Delhi-Mumbai Expressway will not just connect the two cities faster, but also link industrial hubs, strengthen Gati Shakti logistics, and accelerate growth across Gujarat, Rajasthan and Maharashtra"

NITIN GADKARI
Union Minister of Road Transport and Highways

THE PAYOFF

A 2025 government-commissioned study by IIM Bangalore has found that Bharatmala has already improved logistics efficiency, reduced freight costs,